

“There’s nothing else we can do,” Ben said, raising his voice. “We have to pay the mortgage. We don’t want to foreclose.”

“I don’t care if we do,” Naomi said, beginning to cry. “I don’t think I can take much more of this.” Then she added, “I’m going out for a while. I just need to get away and think.”

With that, Naomi went walking and wound up at her parents’ house. When Naomi’s dad came home that evening, he said, “Hi—I didn’t expect to see you. You don’t look happy. What’s the problem?”

“Oh, Daddy, we’re in such a financial mess, and I can’t get Ben to be honest with me. We seem to get into more trouble every month.”

Naomi’s father was wise enough to call Ben and ask him to come over and talk. Ben explained the problem of the credit union payment being taken out of the first of the month’s paycheck, when he thought it would be taken out of the second check. Ben assured Naomi’s father it was all a misunderstanding and that he would be able to make the adjustment the next month.

Rather than allow them to take out a second mortgage, Naomi’s dad decided to lend them the money himself. He just asked that Ben pay back the loan as soon as he could. Ben assured him that he would do so and that it would be no longer than two months.

Even a casual observer could see at this point that giving Ben and Naomi more money was not the answer. But it’s often much easier to see the truth in someone else’s life than it is in your own. Certainly Ben wasn’t trying to deceive anyone. He just didn’t have enough information about the way finances worked to make an intelligent decision.

The loan from Naomi’s father didn’t solve any problems. It merely delayed the inevitable. Within a couple of months, bills were backing up again. Creditors were calling day and night. It was almost impossible for Naomi to concentrate on her schoolwork. For the first time in her life she began to let her grades slip. That put additional pressure on her, especially when her father called her cell to chide her about her midterm grades. “Naomi, we’re glad to help